

English Ladder

Teaching Guide

Speak, Talk, Say, Tell

A concise classroom guide with lesson flow, teaching cues, and a ready-to-use answer key built around the same English Ladder concept sheet.



Grammar Concepts #36

Key Points

Summary and Additional Examples

Exceptions and Special Cases

Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **Speak, Talk, Say, Tell** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept #36 ► Speak | Talk | Say | Tell

The four words below are often confused. Be sure to use them correctly.

Speak

You can "speak" loudly, quietly, politely, and with an accent. You can "speak" French or Spanish. You "speak" to an audience if making a largely formal presentation. If you "speak your mind" (idiom), you are giving your honest opinion.

Say

If you "say" what someone else said, you are usually repeating their exact words such as in "Tom said 'I'm coming'." You can also say "He said (to me) he would come." But you can not omit the "to" such as in "He said me he would come."

Talk

You can "talk" loudly, quietly, politely, and with an accent. When a baby utters her first words we say "She's talking!" If you are giving "a talk" to an audience, it is often more of a casual two-way conversation than when you give a formal speech.

Tell

When "telling" someone what Tom said, you usually don't use Tom's exact words. You only convey the main idea as in "He told me he would come." You can "tell" a joke, a story, a lie, and the truth. You can also "tell" (order) someone to do something.

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At a Glance

Lesson focus Speak, Talk, Say, Tell	Suggested timing 45-60 minutes
Core objective Students explain the target pattern clearly and apply it accurately in controlled practice and discussion.	Materials Student PDF, the concept image, board space, and time for partner checking.

Suggested Lesson Flow

Warm-up

Display the concept image and ask learners to predict the rule behind **Speak, Talk, Say, Tell** before reading the explanation.

Model

Walk through the Core Idea and the sections on Key Points, Summary and Additional Examples, Exceptions and Special Cases. Pause after each part so students can restate the pattern in plain English.

Guided practice

Project two or three examples from the concept sheet and ask pairs to explain why each choice works, not just what the answer is.

Independent work

Assign the 24 practice items for quiet work, partner checking, and final feedback.

Closure

Ask students to create one new sentence or mini-example of their own that follows the same pattern.

Likely Learner Errors

- Learners may overgeneralize the first pattern they notice. Keep returning to **Key Points, Summary and Additional Examples, Exceptions and Special Cases** and ask students to explain what changes from one example to the next.
- Long explanations can hide the signal word or structure. Have students underline the exact phrase that tells them which form, pattern, or response is needed.
- If students can choose an answer but cannot explain it, ask them to justify their choice using words taken directly from the concept sheet.

Differentiation and Delivery Notes



- Support: teach one section at a time, then send students back to **the examples** or the practice set so they can apply the same rule immediately.
- Pair work: let students compare answers aloud before you reveal the key. The explanation step is as important as the final answer.
- Extension: ask stronger students to write two fresh examples or a short dialogue that uses the same target language accurately.

Model Language from the Concept Sheet

- Formal Presentation: "She spoke at the conference about climate change." "The president spoke to the nation last night."
- Language Ability: "He speaks three languages: English, Spanish, and Mandarin." "Do you speak French?"
- Expressing an Opinion: "You should speak your mind if you disagree." "He spoke out against the injustice he witnessed."
- Speaking Manner: "She spoke quietly so as not to disturb anyone." "Please speak loudly so everyone can hear you."
- Casual Conversations: "We talked about the movie we watched last night." "Can we talk later? I'm a bit busy right now."
- Two-way Communication: "I like to talk with my friends about our weekend plans." "She talked to her boss about getting a promotion."



Answer Key

Use this key for whole-class feedback or fast marking.

Item 01 A) He speaks French fluently.

Item 02 B) She said to me that she was coming.

Item 03 C) He told me to close the door.

Item 04 D) Both B and C are correct.

Item 05 B) She told me that she would be late.

Item 06 A) Please speak louder so everyone can hear.

Item 07 B) He gave a talk at the conference.

Item 08 A) He said that he was tired.

Item 09 D) Both A and C are correct.

Item 10 A) He asked her to speak her mind.

Item 11 A) He told me that he was tired.

Item 12 A) She gave a talk about her travels.

Item 13 A) Can you tell us a joke?

Item 14 B) She told me to visit the museum.

Item 15 D) Both A and B are correct.

Item 16 B) She said that she was hungry.

Item 17 B) He talked at the event.

Item 18 A) She said that she was leaving.

Item 19 A) They spoke to the audience in a formal manner.

Item 20 A) Let's talk this over tomorrow.

Item 21 A) He can speak several languages.



Item 22 C) She told me the story.

Item 23 A) Can I tell you something?

Item 24 B) He said he would come.

Feedback Cues

- Item 01: Explanation: ** "Speaks" is correct because it refers to the ability to use a language. "Says," "tells," and "talks" are incorrect because they do not convey the idea of language ability.
- Item 02: Explanation: ** "Said to me" is the correct usage for reporting speech. "Talked," "spoke," and "tell" are either grammatically incorrect or improperly used.
- Item 03: Explanation: ** "Told me" is correct because "tell" requires an object and is followed by the action. The other options either omit the object or misuse the verb form.
- Item 04: Explanation: ** "Talk to" and "talk with" are both correct prepositions that can be used with "talk" depending on the context.
- Item 05: Explanation: ** "Told me" is correct because "tell" requires an object, which is "me" in this case. The other sentences misuse the verb forms or word order.
- Item 06: Explanation: ** "Speak louder" is correct because "speak" is used when referring to the act of producing sound or using one's voice.